

Dhul-Qarnayn: God-Given Authority and the Journey Westward

Based on Qur'an, Surah Al-Kahf (18) : 83-88

Some people asked the Prophet Muhammad about Dhul-Qarnayn. God commanded that a portion of his account be recited to them as a lesson. God explained that He had established Dhul-Qarnayn firmly upon the earth and granted him a means to reach everything he intended. So he followed a way.

He travelled on until he reached the place where the sun sets. There he found it as though setting into a spring of dark, murky water, and near it he found a people. God gave him a choice concerning that people: "O Dhul-Qarnayn, you may either punish them, or show them kindness."

Dhul-Qarnayn answered with the justice of a believing ruler. He said that whoever does wrong, he would punish, after which that person would be returned to his Lord, who would punish him with a terrible punishment. But as for the one who believes and does righteous deeds, he will have the finest reward, and Dhul-Qarnayn would deal with him gently, commanding him only with what is easy.

Thus God portrays a great ruler whose power did not make him heedless. He distinguished between the wrongdoer and the believer, upheld justice without tyranny, and remained aware

that above his authority stood the authority of God, to whom all people return.

Reflection: True power is a trust for upholding justice, not a tool for oppression. Dhul-Qarnayn was given "a way to everything," yet he stayed submissive to God and left each person's final reckoning to Him. The believing leader punishes wrongdoing with fairness and treats the righteous with gentleness.

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